WEEK 10 · LECTURE L2 · UNIT IV

Hybrid and Flexible Work

What the evidence says about working from home, how to design hybrid work, and how to avoid a two tier workforce.

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AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

What this lecture prepares you for

1. Use the randomized evidence on working from home (Bloom et al., 2015; 2024) with its limits.
2. Apply Gratton’s two axes and four perspectives to hybrid design.
3. Explain the two tier hybrid trap, and distinguish temporal, spatial and contractual flexibility.
4. Apply boundary theory and organizational justice to flexible work policy.

ONE SOURCE

The same theories as the in class lecture and the course hub, without the simulation data used in class. Course outcomes: CLO 1 and CLO 5.

COMMIT BEFORE THEORY

Commit to an answer first

A company offers two home working days a week to office staff. What does the strongest randomized evidence suggest about its effect?

A
Performance falls sharply

B
Quitting falls, with no measurable loss in performance or promotion

C
Productivity doubles

D
It has no effect on anything

EXAM LENS

The answer is B (Bloom, Han and Liang, 2024).

BLOOM ET AL. (2015; 2024)

What the experiments show

Full time home working (2015)

Ctrip call center randomized experiment: performance up about 13%, mainly more minutes worked and fewer breaks; quitting roughly halved; but loneliness, and lower promotion for the same performance.

Hybrid, two home days (2024)

Trip.com, 1,612 employees, randomized: resignations down by about a third, no effect on performance reviews or promotions.

EXAM LENS

Randomized evidence is the strongest you can cite: strong evidence, narrow settings (one firm, one country, mostly desk work). Fully remote work has weaker evidence for collaboration and innovation. Risk: proximity bias, as managers favor those they see.

GRATTON (2021)

Designing hybrid work: two axes and four perspectives

Element	The question
Axis: place	From the office to anywhere
Axis: time	From fixed hours to any time (asynchronous)
Jobs and tasks	What does each job need for energy, focus, coordination and cooperation?
Employee preferences	What do people need and want, by life stage and role?
Projects and workflows	Must the workflow be redesigned, or does hybrid simply degrade it?
Inclusion and fairness	Who is eligible, and who is structurally excluded?

EXAM LENS

Designs usually fail on the fourth perspective.

THE TWO TIER HYBRID TRAP

Who can work hybrid?

Desk based staff

In many Indian organizations a minority work in corporate roles with laptops; hybrid by place reaches them.

Everyone else

Store, factory, warehouse, branch and field staff work fixed shifts, often with only a phone, and sometimes absorb the workload of colleagues who are away.

What equity needs

Flexibility in time where place cannot flex: shift choice, swaps, predictable rosters.

EXAM LENS

Hybrid offered only to desk staff creates two tiers: flexibility for some, fixed shifts for the rest, eroding trust across the firm.

FLEXIBILITY BEYOND THE DESK

Three kinds

Kind	Examples	Possible for frontline staff?
Temporal	Flextime, compressed weeks, shift swaps	Yes: app based shift swaps and advance rosters
Spatial	Remote work, co working	Rarely: the work is on site
Contractual	Part time, job sharing, phased retirement	Yes, with equal benefits pro rata

EXAM LENS

Design rule: if place cannot flex, give people control over time.

THEORY IN DEPTH · ASHFORTH, KREINER AND FUGATE (2000)

People manage boundaries between work and home

The core idea

Boundary theory: people segment or integrate their roles, and transitions between roles cost effort.

How it works

Segmentation: strong boundaries, harder transitions, less intrusion. Integration: permeable boundaries, easy transitions, more intrusion both ways. Hybrid removes the commute that marked the boundary; people must now build it.

Limits and critique

Individual preferences vary widely, so one policy rarely suits all.

IN PRACTICE

Let teams agree norms on availability rather than imposing one rule for everyone.

EXAM LENS

Use boundary theory to explain why the same hybrid policy helps some employees and harms others, such as staff now working late every night.

THEORY IN DEPTH · GREENBERG (1987); COLQUITT (2001)

Eligibility decisions are judged on justice

The core idea

Organizational justice has four forms: distributive, procedural, interpersonal and informational.

How it works

People accept unequal outcomes more readily when the process is fair and explained.

Limits and critique

Justice perceptions differ across cultures and status groups.

IN PRACTICE

If frontline staff cannot have hybrid work, explain why, and offer a fair equivalent such as control over shifts.

EXAM LENS

Colquitt’s four dimensions give a precise structure for evaluating any flexibility policy.

FROM THE TEACHING NOTE

The forces behind the future of work

Five forces

Technological convergence (AI, automation, cloud, IoT); demographic shifts; social change (work life integration, purpose, mental health); economic volatility; regulatory evolution.

The organizing question

If work is no longer tied to a place, time or permanent contract, what is HR’s organizing principle?

Course’s Future of Work Paradigms teaching note.

APPLY

Hybrid for a bank, not only its head office

Teaching case (Course framing)

A Mumbai bank with 3,000 head office staff and 22,000 branch staff offers two home days a week to head office. Branch unions call it unfair. Head office managers worry about performance. Some head office staff report working late every night since the policy began.

Work it through

1. What does the experimental evidence say about the managers' worry?
2. Which of Gratton's lenses did the bank skip?
3. Explain the late working with boundary theory.
4. Design one flexibility for branch staff.

COMMON CONFUSIONS

Tempting readings, and better ones

A tempting reading	A better reading
Working from home lowers productivity	Randomized trials found gains or no loss, in specific settings
Hybrid policy is about place	It is about place and time; time is where frontline flexibility lives
Flexibility for some is neutral for others	It can create a two tier workforce and shift workload
One availability rule suits everyone	Boundary preferences differ; let teams agree norms

COMPARE AND EVALUATE

Five lenses on hybrid and flexible work

Lens	Use it to	Watch out for
Bloom et al. (2015; 2024)	Ground claims in randomized evidence	One firm, mostly desk work
Gratton (2021)	Design hybrid by job	Fairness lens is often skipped
Flexibility types	Find flexibility for the frontline	Contractual flexibility needs equal benefits *
Boundary theory (2000)	Explain different effects on people	Preferences vary
Organizational justice	Defend eligibility decisions	Process cannot fully offset outcomes

* Course framing.

PRACTICE FOR THE END TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse

Design a hybrid and flexible work policy for an Indian insurance company with both office and field staff. Use Gratton's framework, the experimental evidence and boundary theory, and explain how you avoid a two tier workforce. **20 marks**

A strong answer: applies Gratton's axes and lenses; uses Bloom and colleagues with their limits; applies segmentation and integration; offers time based flexibility for field staff, with a limit.

"Hybrid work is a privilege of the desk based minority." Critically evaluate using Gratton (2021), organizational justice and the evidence from Bloom et al. **20 marks**

A strong answer: applies all four perspectives; uses experimental evidence with limits; Colquitt's dimensions; proposes temporal and contractual flexibility for frontline staff.

Distinguish temporal, spatial and contractual flexibility with examples. **10 marks**

A strong answer: gives correct, distinct examples of each.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

Four things to remember

1. **The randomized evidence is strong but narrow.**
   Hybrid cut quits by a third with no performance loss, at one firm.

2. **Design through all four perspectives.**
   Especially inclusion and fairness.

3. **Where place cannot flex, give control over time.**
   Avoid the two tier trap.

4. **Boundaries must now be built.**
   And eligibility must be explained.

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

Read for this week

- Gratton, L. (2021). How to do hybrid right. *Harvard Business Review, 99*(3), 66 to 74.
- NITI Aayog (2022); Susskind (2020); Scully-Russ and Torraco (2020).

NOTE

The other works named in this lecture are theory sources for reference, not set readings.

THEORY SOURCES · FOR REFERENCE

Sources for this lecture

- Ashforth, B. E., Kreiner, G. E., & Fugate, M. (2000). All in a day's work: Boundaries and micro role transitions. *Academy of Management Review, 25*(3), 472 to 491. https://doi.org/10.2307/259305
- Bloom, N., Han, R., & Liang, J. (2024). Hybrid working from home improves retention without damaging performance. *Nature, 630*, 920 to 925. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41586-024-07500-2
- Bloom, N., Liang, J., Roberts, J., & Ying, Z. J. (2015). Does working from home work? *The Quarterly Journal of Economics, 130*(1), 165 to 218. https://doi.org/10.1093/qje/qju032
- Colquitt, J. A. (2001). On the dimensionality of organizational justice. *Journal of Applied Psychology, 86*(3), 386 to 400. https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.86.3.386
- Gratton, L. (2021). How to do hybrid right. *Harvard Business Review, 99*(3), 66 to 74.
- Greenberg, J. (1987). A taxonomy of organizational justice theories. *Academy of Management Review, 12*(1), 9 to 22. https://doi.org/10.2307/257990